

1. Sightings

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-05-02T17:26:40+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/May/2/sightings/#atom-everything>

/elsewhere/sightings/ I have a new camera (a Canon R6 Mark II) so I'm taking a lot more photos of birds. I share my best wildlife photos on iNaturalist , and based on yesterday's successful prototype I decided to add those to my blog. I built this feature on my phone using Claude Code for web, as an extension of my beats system for syndicating external content. Here's the PR and prompt. As with my other forms of incoming syndicated content sightings show up on the homepage, the date archive pages, and in site search results. I back-populated over a decade of iNaturalist sightings, which means you that if you search for lemur you'll see my lemur photos from Madagascar in 2019! Tags: blogging , photography , wildlife , ai , inaturalist , generative-ai , llms , ai-assisted-programming , claude-code

2. Introducing talkie: a 13B vintage language model from 1930

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-04-28T02:47:42+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Apr/28/talkie/#atom-everything>

Introducing talkie: a 13B vintage language model from 1930 New project from Nick Levine , David Duvenaud , and Alec Radford (of GPT, GPT-2, Whisper fame). talkie-1930-13b-base (53.1 GB) is a "13B language model trained on 260B tokens of historical pre-1931 English text".

talkie-1930-13b-it (26.6 GB) is a checkpoint "finetuned using a novel dataset of instruction-response pairs extracted from pre-1931 reference works", designed to power a chat interface. You can try that out here . Both models are Apache 2.0 licensed. Since the training data for the base model is entirely out of copyright (the USA copyright cutoff date is currently January 1, 1931), I'm hoping they later decide to release the training data as well. Update on that: Nick Levine on Twitter : Will publish more on the corpus in the future (and do our best to share the data or at least scripts to reproduce it). Their report suggests some fascinating research objectives for this class of model, including: How good are these models at predicting the future? "we calculated the surprisingness of short descriptions of historical events to a 13B model trained on pre-1931 text" Can these models invent things that are past their...

3. A pelican for GPT-5.5 via the semi-official Codex backdoor API

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-04-23T19:59:47+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Apr/23/gpt-5-5/#atom-everything>

GPT-5.5 is out . It's available in OpenAI Codex and is rolling out to paid ChatGPT subscribers. I've had some preview access and found it to be a fast, effective and highly capable model. As is usually the case these days, it's hard to put into words what's good about it - I ask it to build things and it builds exactly what I ask for! There's one notable omission from today's release - the API: API deployments require different safeguards and we are working closely with partners and customers on the safety and security requirements for serving it at scale. We'll bring GPT-5.5 and GPT-5.5 Pro to the API very soon. When I run my pelican benchmark I always prefer to use an API, to avoid hidden system prompts in ChatGPT or other agent harnesses from impacting the results. The OpenClaw backdoor One of the ongoing tension points in the AI world over the past few months has concerned how agent harnesses like OpenClaw and Pi interact with the APIs provided by the big providers. Both OpenAI and Anthropic offer popular monthly subscriptions which provide access to their models at a significant discount to their raw API. OpenClaw integrated directly with this mechanism, and was then blocked...

4. The Talk Show: ?Food and Beverage Director?

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-05-01T02:58:44Z

Link: <https://daringfireball.net/thetalkshow/2026/04/30/ep-446>

MG Siegler returns to the show to discuss Apple's announcement that Tim Cook is stepping aside

(into the role of executive chairman) and John Ternus will become CEO. Sponsored by:
Squarespace : Save 10% off your first purchase of a website or domain using code TALKSHOW .
Drafts : The Swiss Army knife for text on all your Apple devices. Act now to get your first year of Drafts Pro for 50% off. Finalist : A daily planner for iPhone, iPad and Mac, built on proven paper-based planning methods. Use this link to get six months free. ?

5. Scientology ?Speed Running? Trend

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-05-01T02:36:36Z

Link: https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2026/apr/30/hollywood-church-of-scientology-speed-runs?CMP=bsky_gu

Uwa Ede-Osifo, reporting for The Guardian: On any given day, Los Angeles's Hollywood Boulevard teems with tourists and street performers clustered near the area's many landmarks. But in recent months, the strip has been set abuzz for a new reason. Throngs of mostly adolescent boys and young men have been rushing the Church of Scientology's international headquarters on the famed street. The so-called "speed runs" appear to be bids for social media valor ? clips of the raids have amassed millions of views on TikTok ? as much as they are an outgrowth of public intrigue surrounding the church, which has previously drawn accusations of being a cult. Some users have developed blueprints for the building based on information gathered from videos of the raids. I'm not condoning it, of course, but this video of one guy doing it sure was fun to watch. Update: Now the kids are speed running Palantir too . ?

6. New Banksy in London

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-04-30T14:25:27Z

Link: <https://www.instagram.com/reel/DXwf7pis6KT/>

Brilliant statue, hilarious intro video. The greatest artist of our age. ?

7. Editing my LLM assisted Articles

Source: iDiallo.com | Published: Sat, 02 May 2026 03:00:23 GMT

Link: <https://idiallo.com/byte-size/editing-llm-assisted-articles?src=feed>

Last year, I used AI to help me write articles. As I've mentioned before , it's convenient when you are doing so because it saves you time. But the problem comes up when you try to quote those articles back. Whatever you think you wrote is not what's in there. I always cringe when I read them back. As I've said before, I'm rewriting those articles so that they capture my voice, and so that I can actually quote the real thoughts I had in mind at the time of writing. I will show you exactly what the article looked like before and after. From prompt, to the final post, and the new edit. Prompt: Feb 4th, 2025 on DeepSeek I am writing a blog post, help me refine it . It should be a fun read that helps convince readers that building useless tools is part of the journey and career growth. Programmers don't use calculators, they build them and abandon them 3 quarters completed. The start of a project is always exciting. You have an brilliant idea, you have the skills to build it, and you have a blind spot. This blind spot propels you into a journey of excitement, setting up the project, deciding on frameworks, paying for AWS servers. You even get to test some of your ideas in a prototype...

8. How backups work depends on the goals of the people setting them up

Source: Chris's Wiki :: blog | Published: 2026-05-02T20:14:00Z

Link: <https://utcc.utoronto.ca/~cks/space/blog/sysadmin/BackupsDependOnGoals>

One of the recent commotions in my corner of the tech sphere was over an incident where a piece of software deleted a company's production database and all of its backups. The software got all of the backups too because, I'll quote: [Their SaaS provider] stores volume-level backups in the same volume ? a fact buried in their own documentation that says "wiping a volume deletes all backups" ? [...] A lot of people were horrified, but I had some sympathies with the SaaS provider . An important thing about backups is how backups work depends on what you're trying to recover from , and for certain sorts of disasters and recoveries, this decision is perfectly sensible. For a SaaS company, they also depend on customer support needs and what customers are going to want, and the decision can also make sense from that perspective. In

this case, the obvious question is whether the SaaS provider is trying to protect customers from loss of data in the volume or from deliberate deletion of the volume. If what you're protecting people from is an accidental 'DROP TABLE' or an accidental 'rm' (or an accidental overwrite of something important), then in volume backups such as ZFS snapshots make pe...

9. Some of our servers revived themselves unexpectedly

Source: Chris's Wiki :: blog | Published: 2026-05-02T03:55:18Z

Link: <https://utcc.utoronto.ca/~cks/space/blog/sysadmin/ServersSurpriseRevival>

We have a whole building, weekend long power shutdown in the building with our machine room that officially starts tomorrow (Saturday) morning at 5am, which is the motivation for our newly added temporary backup MX . Because we like to be in control of both the shutdown and the startup of our machines, we turn machines off in advance for scheduled outages (there's not much we can do about unscheduled ones). For various reasons we did the shutdown earlier this evening. (One reason to start machines under controlled circumstances is that sometimes hardware fails , things go wrong , or you discover unfortunate aspects of your environment (also). At least these days we've mostly learned lessons from previous power shutdowns and startups , although there are aspects I hadn't fully absorbed and will write about later.) During the shutdown, something surprising happened, which is that all of our ZFS file servers came back to life . We definitely ran ' poweroff ' on each of them and they were off the network for some amount of time, but then my co-workers doing work in the machine room noticed that they were all powered back on. We ran ' poweroff ' on the rebooted servers and they shut...

10. A GitHub for maintainers

Source: Andrew Nesbitt | Published: 2026-05-02T10:00:00+00:00

Link: <https://nesbitt.io/2026/05/02/a-github-for-maintainers.html>

Mat Duggan wrote up what he'd want from a GitHub replacement and it's a reasonable list if you're the one at the keyboard. Stacked PRs, pre-push feedback, offline review, lazy history, graduated approval states. Reading through it I kept noticing that almost every item is a client problem, and the clients are already solving it. Jujutsu does stacked changes better than any web UI is going to. Review is moving into editors. Pre-commit feedback wants to run on your machine, where the files are. The things I want from a forge are the things that can't move to the client because they involve more than one party. Who depends on you, who you depend on, what happened to that project you forked from three years ago, where the active development moved to when the original went quiet. Almost none of that happens inside a single repository. It happens in the relationships between them, and that's the part GitHub has barely touched in years and the part none of the would-be replacements are talking about either. So my version of Mat's list is mostly about coordination between projects. The only relationship between two repos that GitHub actually models is the fork, because in 2008 the way you...

11. Reading List 05/02/2026

Source: Construction Physics | Published: Sat, 02 May 2026 12:01:30 GMT

Link: <https://www.construction-physics.com/p/reading-list-05022026>

Chilling effects in the build-to-rent sector, how fast could robot manufacturing scale up, PJM's new interconnection queue, the backlash against battery storage, and more.

12. Pluralistic: The prehistory of the Democratic Nuremberg Caucus (02 May 2026)

Source: Pluralistic: Daily links from Cory Doctorow | Published: Sat, 02 May 2026 11:22:11+0000

Link: <https://pluralistic.net/2026/05/02/denazification/>

Today's links The prehistory of the Democratic Nuremberg Caucus: Do bounties for ICE whistleblowers next! Hey look at this: Delights to delectate. Object permanence: Colbert v GWB; Wallaby milk; Jay Rosen's journalism precepts; Radical Media(TM); What is carried interest? TCP over pigeon; BNL v copyright; RIP Joanna Russ; GOP forcing students to repay scam loans. Upcoming appearances: Berlin, NYC, Barcelona, Hay-on-Wye, London, NYC. Recent appearances:

Where I've been. Latest books: You keep readin' em, I'll keep writin' 'em. Upcoming books: Like I said, I'll keep writin' 'em. Colophon: All the rest. The prehistory of the Democratic Nuremberg Caucus ([permalink](#)) Comrade Trump continues his unbroken streak of destroying the American empire's grip on the world, hastening the renewables transition, de-dollarizing global trade, and killing the world's suicidal habit of entrusting its digital life to America's defective, enshittified tech exports: <https://pluralistic.net/2026/04/20/praxis/#acceleration> But Comrade Trump's ambitious praxis knows no bounds. Now, he's helping to remake the Democratic Party as a muscular opposition with a serious commitment to workers' interests over billio...

13. callgraph analysis

Source: the website of jyn | Published: 2026-05-03T00:00:00+00:00

Link: <https://jyn.dev/callgraph-analysis/>

Writing custom Rust lints for fun and profit

14. Scaling, stretching and shifting sinusoids

Source: Eli Bendersky's website | Published: 2026-05-02T07:17:00-07:00

Link: <https://eli.thegreenplace.net/2026/scaling-stretching-and-shifting-sinusoids/>

This is a brief and simple [1] explanation of how to adjust the standard sinusoid $\sin(x)$ to change its amplitude, frequency and phase shift. More precisely, given the general function: $y(x) = A \cdot \sin(\omega \cdot x + \theta)$ We'll see how adjusting the parameters , and affect the ?

15. Cybersecurity Is Like Food Safety: Digital HACCP

Source: Bert Hubert's writings | Published: Thu, 18 Feb 2021 09:31:12 +0100

Link: <https://berthub.eu/articles/posts/cybersecurity-is-like-food-safety/>

There are lots of calls to invest in improving cybersecurity. But it struck me that it doesn't work like that. Not getting hacked is not so much a question of buying the right stuff. It is a question of doing the right things and understanding what you are doing. It is easy to demand that people ?invest? in something. You can even supply them with the money to do so.

16. COVID-19 Scenarios and a Short Break

Source: Bert Hubert's writings | Published: Sun, 17 Jan 2021 14:15:50 +0100

Link: <https://berthub.eu/articles/posts/covid-scenarios-and-a-short-break/>

Hi everyone, With apologies for flooding the airwaves and timelines with way too many posts and tweets, here's one more post, the last COVID-19 related one for a while. I've been trying to provide high quality answers to the many questions I receive via email and various social media. I've also been trying to help many many people that found worrying news online & sent it to me, either for reassurance or simply to challenge me.

17. How Tech Loses Out over at Companies, Countries and Continents

Source: Bert Hubert's writings | Published: Sat, 16 Jan 2021 20:13:17 +0100

Link: <https://berthub.eu/articles/posts/how-tech-loses-out/>

This article is part of a series on (European) innovation and capabilities. Hi everyone, This is a transcript of my presentation over at the European Microwave Week 2020, actually held in 2021. You can find the video here and the slides here. I'd like to thank Frank van Vliet, general chair of the EMW, for inviting me to do this talk. The words have only been edited lightly - it is still presentation style, so here and there the sentences are not written like how they'd be in a more formal piece of work.